

4.2.1 Pidgin

Pidgin (formerly Gaim) is a cross-platform, free, and open source chat client that works across Windows and Linux. Download it from www.pidgin.im/download. Pidgin works with a wide variety of services, right from the major ones like AIM, Yahoo, Google Talk, MySpaceIM, and MSN to the more exotic ones like ICQ, IRC, Gadu-Gadu, Bonjour, QQ and Zephyr. The latest version is 2.3.1. Pidgin can also be used in a non-graphical console mode; this mode is called Finch.



Pidgin supports more protocols than you'll ever need

Pidgin integrates well with window managers in operating systems, enabling it to be operated from the System Tray. Once installation is done, right-click on the Pidgin icon and click on Accounts. After clicking on Add, choose the service you want (Gmail users would choose XMPP here) and enter your login and password. You can add as many accounts as you want, because Pidgin is sure to support almost all your IM accounts. When you fire up Pidgin, you will be prompted to enter all your passwords for the individual services. All your friends who are online will be displayed in your Buddy List, arranged either alphabetically or categorised as services.

Pidgin incorporates quite a slew of features; it supports most standard features like emoticons, notifications for different actions, file transfers, and tabbed conversations in a single window. However, some features go beyond what is offered in other similar types of software: you can customise sound alerts for different actions like a friend coming online or going offline. Go to Preferences > Sounds and check out the options. Conversations can be stored in a log file, and the misspelt words in a conversation can be highlighted.